

# What Money Can't Buy

When we started paying off debt I (still Jen) immediately cut out happy hours, restaurants, and other high-cost activities with friends. And I was, to no one's surprise, miserable.

*The problem with trying to cut out dinners and coffees for the sake of cutting costs is that you're also cutting out whatever reason you had for buying those things.* Unless you identify what you're truly after, you'll keep spending to acquire things that money can't buy.

When I examined my needs and found that relationships were at the core of why I was going out, I was able to get creative in how I met the need, instead of immediately buying the quick fix. But it took time to get there.

It might be why some of your prior attempts at "controlling" your spending didn't last long or left you saying, "Why do I keep overspending when I don't want to?" When I identified what I was after, I started looking for ways to pursue it that didn't cost me money. I invited friends over for wine nights or a potluck, we attended free movies in the park, or brought our coffees to the playground.

The first principle of values-based spending and buying what you love is knowing that the things we love most can't be bought. And since that's a very abstract thing to say, we like to give it some specificity by naming a few things that we and almost all our listeners have stated are their highest values. And they are all conveniently F words.

We call them the four F's: **family**, **friends**, **faith**, and **fulfilling work**. You can absolutely add your own (bonus points if it's another F word), but these are the internal needs that we've found most important to us and that have been echoed throughout the studies we've read.

Like in a Pew Research study<sup>3</sup> where two separate surveys were administered that asked the same question: What makes your life feel meaningful, fulfilling, or satisfying? The first poll was open-ended, meaning respondents could enter anything. The second was closed, meaning respondents could only choose from a list of fifteen possible sources. It also asked which of these sources gave respondents the most meaning and fulfillment. Across both surveys, the most popular answer was clear and consistent: Family gave life the most meaning and fulfillment. After that, respondents had many answers, but there were four that came up at or near the top of both surveys: career, money, faith, and friends. A lot of